

REVIEW DRAFT · NOT FOR PUBLICATION

Names, Not Numbers

How to know which real people your marketing produced, and why the platform total is not the answer

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Publication review

Status: **draft**. Publishable: **no**. 7666 words. Every number in this book carries its source in brackets.

match-back not yet true on all accounts; ship after the Zap fix. The book is written as a practice and a warning, with Momentum's own thirteen unmet match-back promises as chapter 6, and it never claims match-back as a live capability; so flipping this flag after the fix needs no rewrite of the body. Before it ships:

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- 01** Dillon reads it as himself and keeps or cuts every first-person claim.
 - 02** The inline [source: ...] tags and the frontmatter sources list carry client folder names (kimberly-james-bridal, omega-landscaping, onsite-concrete-landscape, fagan-painting, nexla, and others); strip or convert them to numbered endnotes before anything leaves the building, because the body text is anonymized and the tags are not.
 - 03** No client is named in the body; if Mac wants any story named, permission must be on file first.
 - 04** The free 15-minute snapshot is the only ask and is described per PLAN.md; confirm it exists as a real page or intake path before the last section points anyone at it.

Names, Not Numbers

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About Momentum AI

How to know which real people your marketing produced, and why the platform total is not the answer.

Momentum AI Field Notes, No. 5. Dillon Mohr. Draft, September 7, 2026.

How to read the brackets. Every number in this book has a source in square brackets. Client figures are labeled the way our own evidence file labels them. "Platform total" is a number a platform reported: impressions, clicks, "conversions." It's what a tag fired. It is not a person. "Verified outcome" is a number reconciled to a named person, a booked job, or a dollar. "Client-reported" is something an owner told us that our files don't independently prove. Paths that start with research/ are inside the folder this book was written in (... \momentum-360\deliverables\2026-09-07-google-aistudio-batch\). Paths that start with clients/ are inside ... \client-operations\clients\. Paths that start with M360/ are our own agency folder inside that tree. Paths that start with VAULT/ are our internal knowledge base. PLAN.md is the AI division plan dated September 4, 2026. Search volumes are monthly, United States, from one keyword tool's index on September 7, 2026, at the tool's stated 0.7 confidence; they're estimates, not counts of people. Where I have no evidence, I say so in the sentence.

Who this is for, and who it isn't

This is for you if you run a service business - landscaping, HVAC, painting, a bridal shop, a law office, a dental practice - and you pay for marketing. Through an agency or on your own card. Your report says conversions went up. Your front desk says the phone was quiet. You'd like to know which one is lying, and you'd like to find out with a spreadsheet, not a data-science hire.

It's also for the agency that keeps promising a client a lead list and can't produce it. Chapter 6 is about why that might be, because it was us.

This is not for you if you sell online with clean order IDs (you have a milder version of this problem and need a different book), if you're an enterprise marketer who says "marketing mix model" without smiling, or if you want a tool review. I'm not going to tell you which call-tracking vendor or CRM to buy. I'm going to tell you what the tool has to do, so you can ask any vendor whether theirs does it.

It's also not for anyone who wants to be told their agency has this handled. Including mine. We have not solved attribution. Nobody has. What we have is a list of the ways it breaks, learned the expensive way, and a rule about what we're allowed to claim. That's the book.

01

Are my Google Ads conversions real?

Short answer. Some of them. A conversion is an event a tag fired, not a person who hired you. The number in your report can include duplicates, tests, spam, clicks on a phone icon that never connected, and the same form counted three ways. Until each conversion is matched to a named person, treat it as a platform total, not a result.

Here's the thing nobody says on a sales call: Google doesn't know if you got the job. Neither does Meta. They know a tag fired. Somebody clicked something, a page loaded, a bit of code said "conversion," and a number went up. Whether a human being with a driveway and a checkbook was on the other end is not something the platform can see, and it's not something it's going to ask.

So "are my conversions real" has an honest answer: they're real events. Whether they're real customers is a separate question, and the report doesn't answer it. Three accounts from our own files, anonymized, show how far apart those two things can get.

The account with the counter unplugged. When we took over Google Ads for an enterprise data-integration software company in August 2026, the account showed \$115,434.23 in lifetime spend, 26,915 clicks, and 133.28 reported conversions at \$866.07 each, with the conversion tag reported inactive [source: VAULT/01_Clients/Nexla/overview.md, "Lifetime account baseline"; platform total]. Read that again. A hundred and thirty-three conversions, eight hundred dollars apiece, from a tag that wasn't on. The number was in the report. The tag behind it was off. Those two facts had been sitting next to each other for a long time.

The account with fourteen counters. A Northern California concrete and landscape contractor serving Solano County had a Google account that reported 87 conversion events across three overlapping 28-day windows between May and August 2026. The same account had 14 enabled conversion actions, including duplicate primary actions for forms, calls, contacts and click-to-call, and Enhanced Conversions wasn't recording [source: clients/onsite-concrete-landscape/deliverables/2026-08-12-call-volume-recovery/live-audit-and-change-plan.md; platform total]. In the most recent window, every one of the 21.99 reported events came from a campaign that was paused. The live campaign reported zero [source: same file]. Our own July report for that client

showed 44 Google leads and said in the same breath that qualified estimates were "not reconciled" [source: M360/2026-08-02-july-2026-client-monthly-reports/reports-data.mjs lines 69, 89; platform total]. Eighty-seven events. Fourteen ways to count. Zero named estimates.

The account converting on someone else's name. A Colorado Springs landscaping and concrete contractor's Performance Max campaign showed 13 platform conversions at a \$114.74 platform cost per conversion on \$1,491.65 of spend [source: clients/omega-landscaping/paid-media/correction-packet-2026-07-16-qualified-lead-reconciliation.md, "Verified facts"; platform total]. The owner's complaint on Slack was that callers thought they were a different company. A 30-day read found four of the search-term conversions attributed to a query that was a competitor's business name, which Google was listing as a top bidding signal [source: VAULT/01_Clients/Omega Landscaping/Agent Memory.md, "Verified live update - 2026-07-30"]. The platform was reporting conversions from people looking for somebody else. Google's recommendation at the time was to switch to Maximize Conversions at a \$161.16 target, trained on that data. We declined [source: same file, "Live optimization follow-up"].

None of these are exotic. They're the default state of an ad account nobody has audited. The counter is on or it's off. It counts once or it counts three times. It counts the right thing or a nearby thing. And in every case the report looks the same: a number, a trend line, a cost per.

The rule at the top of every report

Our monthly paid-media reports carry this line in the source file: "Platform activity is reported separately from qualified inquiries, appointments, estimates, bookings, and revenue. Conversion reporting remains pending validation wherever the exact action definition, attribution window, or downstream outcome is not fully reconciled." [source: M360/2026-08-31-august-2026-paid-media-monthly-reports/reports-data.mjs line 3]

That sentence exists because of the three accounts above. It's the difference between a number and a result. Platform total on one side of the page. Named people on the other. If the two columns don't meet, the report has to say so, in words, not in a footnote.

So: are your conversions real? Some. Which ones? That's the rest of the book.

What is marketing attribution for a business with a phone, a form and a front desk?

Short answer. Attribution is writing down where each customer came from, in a way you could defend to your accountant. Not a model. Not a percentage. A column in a spreadsheet next to a person's name that says "Google ad, August 14, called the tracking number." If you can't fill that column, you don't have attribution; you have a dashboard.

Search "marketing attribution" and page one is an attribution vendor, Amazon Ads, Supermetrics, Wikipedia, Adobe, Domo and HubSpot [source: research/aeo-geo-topic-research.md §1, cluster 11]. All written for a company with a marketing department and a data warehouse. The term itself is falling, from around 1,600 searches a month in late 2024 to 720 in July 2026 [source: same file]. "Lead attribution," the phrase an owner would actually use, gets about 70 [source: same file]. Nobody's searching for this. They're just quietly unsure whether their ads work.

Here's the plain version.

For a business with a phone, a form and a front desk, attribution means that for each new customer you can answer one question: how did this person find us? Not in aggregate. This person. And the answer has to come from evidence, not from the platform's opinion of itself.

You have three sources of truth, and none of them is the ad platform:

1. **Your phone log.** Who called, when, from what number, how long, and whether anyone picked up.
2. **Your inbox or form tool.** Who submitted what, when, from which page.
3. **Your CRM, booking tool, or the spreadsheet your office manager keeps.** Who became a quote, a job, a paid invoice.

Attribution is the wiring between those three and the ad platform. The platform says "a conversion happened at 2:14 pm on August 14 from campaign X." Your phone log says "a call came in at 2:14 pm from a 720 number and lasted six minutes." Your CRM says "that number belongs to a person who booked a patio for October." Now you have a name, a source, and a dollar. That's attribution. It's three lookups.

The ladder

Our reporting contract, the internal document every ad report has to follow, separates platform events from business outcomes and defines the outcomes as a ladder: received, deduplicated, contacted, qualified, booked, won, revenue [source: M360/2026-07-26-paid-media-reporting-contract.md, "Business-outcome reconciliation ledger" row; research/evidence-bank.md §C]. Platform events sit outside the ladder. They're where the ladder might start, not a rung on it.

That ladder is the whole model. You don't need first-touch versus last-touch versus data-driven. For a business with two or three channels, pick the touch you can prove - the tracking number they dialed, the click ID on the form - and write the others down as notes. You can get fancy later. Most businesses never need to.

Why this is easier and harder than the enterprise version

Easier: you have fewer channels, fewer pages, and you personally know most of your customers. A landscaper can walk a whole month of leads in an afternoon.

Harder: the phone. A lot of service-business leads call, and a call is the one thing a web tag can't see. A tap on a phone number is not a call. A call is not a conversation. A conversation is not a quote. Every step on that path is a place the count can go wrong, and chapter 5 is about the one tool that makes the phone visible.

Attribution, then, is not a product you buy. It's a habit of writing the source down next to the name, every time, and refusing to report a number you can't trace back to a person.

Why does my agency's report not match my phone?

Short answer. Because the report counts events and your phone counts people. Between them sit a dozen small leaks: a tag on the wrong event, two actions counting the same form, "every" instead of "one" call per click, tests never removed, spam with a click ID, and a notification email that carries a link instead of a name. Each leak is boring. Together they explain the gap.

When an owner tells me "the report says 40 leads and I got maybe six calls," my first assumption is not that the agency is lying. It's that nobody has walked the pipe. Here are the leaks we found in our own accounts over the summer of 2026, each one with a file behind it.

Leak 1: zero when it should be something. A Philadelphia bridal boutique's Performance Max campaign ran at \$20 a day and served 54,814 impressions for \$585.42 over a 30-day window while reporting zero conversions. A separate week showed 365 clicks and zero tracked conversions [source: clients/kimberly-james-bridal/paid-media/correction-packet-2026-07-16-google-conversion-tracking.md, "Verified facts"; platform total]. Brides were clicking. Something was happening on the other end. The counter said nothing. The correction packet we wrote listed the possible causes - primary action missing, campaign goal unselected, the scheduler dropping source parameters - under the heading "Hypotheses, not findings," and refused to touch bids or budget until the appointment path was proved end to end [source: same file]. You can't optimize toward a counter that isn't counting.

Leak 2: something when it should be zero. A small-town Illinois HVAC company's new site had a three-step service-request form that could submit during the transition between steps, storing a lead with no name, no phone and no email [source: clients/shadow-heating-cooling/deliverables/2026-07-23-website-qa/analytics-and-form-report.md, "Form issue found and repaired"]. That's a conversion. It's also nobody.

Leak 3: counting a nearby thing. A multi-city events company selling themed bar-crawl tickets had a spring setup that counted an Eventbrite form-submit proxy as a purchase, rather than a verified completed order [source: clients/bar-crawl-usa/deliverables/2026-08-21-halloween-landing-

pages/rebuild/PUBLICATION_RECEIPT.md, "Ticket and search integration update"]. The software company from chapter 1 had its Google Ads conversion routed from a generic form-submit event instead of the form-success event, with enhanced-conversion coverage at 27% [source: clients/hexla/context/operating-context.md line 1082; platform total]. In both cases the tag fired on "they tried," not "it worked."

Leak 4: counting it twice. The Colorado Springs contractor's "Calls from ads" action was set to count Every call rather than One per click; we changed it to One on September 5, 2026 [source: clients/omega-landscaping/deliverables/2026-09-05-google-ads-optimization-review/call-count-applied.md]. Same person, same click, redial once because the line dropped: two conversions. Add the fourteen-action account from chapter 1 and you can see how 87 events happen.

Leak 5: spam with a click ID. Eleven demo-request submissions came in over three days on the software account. One was our own labeled test. Seven carried a Google click ID from a Performance Max campaign. Several showed keyboard-mash text, repeated fake identities and a placeholder phone number. The form had captcha turned off [source: clients/hexla/deliverables/2026-08-31-hubspot-form-spam-review.md; verified outcome, records inspected]. Those seven are "conversions." Real click, real ad, fake person. The recommendation was to turn on captcha and gibberish detection but not to block submissions just because they carry a click ID, because "a GCLID is not itself a spam signal" [source: same file].

Leak 6: counting nothing because the tag isn't there. A retail smoothie-kiosk brand with locations inside convenience stores ran nine store campaigns pointed at a shared location-finder site. That site loaded no Google tag, no Tag Manager, no GA4, no Ads tag. The directions clicks the account was optimizing toward never reached Google Ads at all [source: clients/replenish-7-eleven/paid-media/2026-08-31-location-finder-launch-audit.md]. The campaign was steering by a compass that wasn't wired to anything.

Leak 7: the notification that carries a link instead of a name. This one gets its own chapter. It's the one that cost us thirteen promises.

The phone leaks too

The gap runs both ways. Your phone's count isn't clean either. When we wired our own call tracking into our own CRM in July 2026, the numbers for July 1-27 were: 352 calls, 263 inbound, 101 answered, 162 missed. A 38.4% answer rate. Every call was associated to a contact, and 0% of them had an owner assigned [source: M360/2026-07-27-callrail-hubspot-agent-completion.md, "HubSpot live verification"; platform total]. That's our phone, not a client's. Which of those 162 missed calls was a real customer? No idea. That's the point.

So when the report doesn't match the phone, the honest answer is: neither one is right yet. The report is over-counting events. The phone is under-counting connections. Attribution is the work of making them meet in the middle, at a name.

04

How do I track leads from Google Ads to actual customers?

Short answer. Three plumbing fixes, in order. One: a tracking phone number on the ads, so a call carries its source. Two: a form notification that puts the lead's name, phone, and source fields in the email body, not behind a link. Three: a source field in your CRM or booking sheet that a human fills in on every new record. Get admin access first.

Before the three fixes, there's a fix zero, and it's the one that stalls most projects.

Fix 0: hold admin access yourself

In July 2026 we published a Google Ads lead form for the Colorado Springs contractor: full name, email, phone, ZIP, which service, phone number verified [source: VAULT/01_Clients/Omega Landscaping/Agent Memory.md, "Direct lead capture and access audit - 2026-07-30"]. Good form. Then we tried to connect the lead export to a Google Sheet through Zapier so the leads would land somewhere a human could see them. It couldn't be authorized. Our login had Standard access; the client's own Gmail address was the account Admin [source: same file]. Until that's fixed, the only way to get those leads out is a manual CSV download from the lead-form asset table [source: same file].

The lesson isn't "get admin access." The lesson is: if you're the owner, you should be the admin of every account with your money in it, and you should be the one granting access to the agency, not the other way around. If your agency created the Google Ads account and you've never logged in, fix that this week. Everything in this chapter depends on somebody being able to turn the export on.

Fix 1: a tracking number on the ads

A phone number that only appears in your ads and on the landing page they point to. When it rings, the call came from an ad. That's the whole trick. Chapter 5 covers doing it without breaking your Google listing.

Fix 2: a form notification with the lead in the body

This is the fix that broke us, so I'll be specific about what "in the body" means. When someone submits your form, an email goes somewhere. Open that email. It should contain, as plain text you can read without clicking anything:

- Name, phone, email
- What they asked for (the service dropdown, the message)
- The page they submitted from
- The source fields: UTM source, medium and campaign, and the click ID (a `gclid` from Google; `fbclid`, `fbc` or `fbp` from Meta)
- A timestamp and a submission ID

If the email says "New lead! Click here to view," you don't have a lead notification. You have a link to a lead notification. Those aren't the same, and the difference is chapter 6.

The reference implementation in our files is a Pittsburgh residential and commercial painting company. After a repair on July 13, 2026, its three website forms carry UTMs, Meta click identifiers, campaign, ad set, ad, placement, landing page, referrer and a shared event ID, and browser and server lead events share that ID so Meta doesn't double count [source: `~/Documents\Codex\2026-07-12\did-you-get-a-chance-to\outputs\reports\Fagan_Attribution_Audit_2026-06-22_to_2026-07-12.md`, "Production repair completed July 13, 2026"]. Before the repair, none of the four real inquiries found in the June-July review could be proven to have come from Meta, because the old notification emails kept no click or campaign identifiers [source: same file]. The forms were fine. The email was throwing away the evidence.

One more thing that review taught us: of 22 automation runs on that account between June 15 and July 12, 4 were qualified inquiries and 18 were solicitations, tests, or duplicate replies [source: same file; verified outcome, classified from raw notification bodies]. The notification count was 22. The people count was 4. Get the fields in the body and you can tell them apart in a minute.

Fix 3: a source field in the CRM

A required field on every new record. A dropdown, not free text: Google Ads, Meta, Google organic, referral, repeat, unknown. Whoever creates the record fills it in from the evidence - the tracking number that rang, the click ID in the email - not from asking the customer "how did you hear about us." Ask that too; write it in a second field. People say "Google" when they mean the map, the ad, or a friend who Googled you.

If you don't have a CRM, a spreadsheet with a Source column is a CRM for this purpose. The tool matters less than the rule: no record without a source.

And two settings while you're in there

In the ad platform: one primary conversion action per real outcome. If a form submit and a "contact" and a "lead" all count as primary for the same form, you have three counters for one person. Set call counting to One per click. Demote or remove everything else. That's most of what the fourteen-action account needed.

On the site: your thank-you page should be set to noindex and nofollow so nobody lands on it from search and fires a conversion by accident [source: Fagan attribution audit, item 8 of the repair list]. And tests are never leads. Our bridal client's blueprint says it in one line: "Tests must never be counted as leads, appointments, or bookings" [source: clients/kimberly-james-bridal/paid-media/correction-packet-2026-07-16-google-conversion-tracking.md, "Verified facts"]. Write it in yours.

05

Do I need call tracking, and will it wreck my Google listing?

Short answer. If more than a few of your leads call, yes. A tracking number on your ads tells you which calls came from ads; a recording tells you whether the caller wanted a quote or a job. It won't wreck your listing if you keep your real number as the primary on Google Business Profile and use tracking numbers only on ads and landing pages, or swap numbers by session.

"Call tracking" gets about 1,600 searches a month; "call tracking software" gets 880 [source: [research/aeo-geo-topic-research.md §1, cluster 11](#)]. More than attribution, which makes sense. Owners don't want a theory. They want to know who called.

What it gives you

Call tracking is a pool of phone numbers that forward to your real line and log everything on the way through: the number that was dialed (which tells you the source), the caller's number, the time, how long it lasted, whether it was answered, and if you turn it on, a recording. That's it. It's a phone bill with better columns.

What those columns let you do is turn "6 calls" into six rows with a person in each. A caller ID you can look up in your CRM. A duration that separates a wrong number from a twenty-minute conversation about a retaining wall. A recording that tells you whether it was a customer or a vendor selling you SEO.

What "call conversion" means without it

Without call tracking, Google's "Calls from ads" conversion counts a tap on the phone number. That's a tap, not a connection. On September 5, 2026 we converted the Colorado Springs contractor's website phone number from plain text to a real tel: link and verified it on desktop and a phone-sized viewport. The file says, in so many words, that this "removes a click-to-call

obstacle" and "does not prove a connected call" [source: clients/omega-landscaping/paid-media/reviews/2026-09-04-phone-link-published.md]. That's the right way to describe it. A tap is an intent. A logged, answered call with a duration is a lead.

Our definition of a call lead, from the recovery plan for the Northern California contractor: an accepted form receipt, or a connected, service-fit call. Everything else stays secondary [source: clients/onsite-concrete-landscape/deliverables/2026-08-12-call-volume-recovery/live-audit-and-change-plan.md]. Connected. Service-fit. Two words that turn a platform total into a person.

Without wrecking your listing

The fear is real: put a different number on your Google Business Profile and you can confuse Google about which business is which, and you can lose the history tied to your real number. So don't.

- Keep your real number as the primary number on Google Business Profile, your website footer, and every directory. That's the number Google associates with your business.
- Put the tracking number in the ads and on the landing page the ads point to. Only there.
- If you want to track calls from organic visitors too, use dynamic number insertion: the site shows the real number by default and swaps in a tracking number only for visitors who arrived from an ad, based on the session. Organic visitors and Google's crawler see the real number.
- Never let a tracking number get scraped into a directory. Check your listings a month after you set it up.

I don't have a measurement from our own accounts of what a misplaced tracking number does to a listing's ranking. This is practice, not a study. The practice is cheap and the mistake is expensive, which is enough for me.

On recordings: some states require both parties to consent. Play the "this call may be recorded" message. I'm not a lawyer, and this isn't legal advice; check your state.

What our own phone looked like

I'll show you ours, because it's the only one I have permission to show. When we wired call tracking into our CRM on July 27, 2026, the July-to-date numbers were 352 calls, 101 answered, 162 missed, a 38.4% answer rate, and 0% of calls had an owner assigned in the CRM [source: M360/2026-07-27-callrail-hubspot-agent-completion.md; platform total]. We set up after-hours

routing that day and a missed-call text-back [source: same file, "Live CallRail configuration"]. A 24-hour read two weeks later showed 16 completed call events, 11 answered, 2 unanswered, 3 abandoned [source: M360/2026-08-11-hubspot-contact-alert-and-daily-health-report.md, "CallRail account and reporting repair"; platform total]. That's one day. It's not a before-and-after, and I don't have a full month after the change to show you. What I have is a phone I can finally see.

That's the honest pitch for call tracking. Not "more leads." Visibility into the leads you already have, one row per human.

06

Why did my agency promise a lead list thirteen times and never send it?

Short answer. Because the lead list wasn't late. It was impossible. We promised named-lead match-back nine times to one client, twice to a second, twice to a third, and it stalled a fourth. On three of those accounts the lead notification carried a link, not a lead. On the one account where it worked, the automation parsed the lead into the email body. One setting. Thirteen promises.

This is the chapter the book exists for. I'm going to tell it straight, with the clients anonymized because none of them has agreed to be named, and with the dates, because dates are what make it a fact instead of a story.

What we promised

Conversion-to-named-lead match-back. A monthly list: here are the conversions the platform reported, here is the actual person each one was, here's what happened to them. We told a Colorado Springs landscaping and concrete contractor we'd send it nine times. We told a Philadelphia bridal boutique twice. We told a Northern California concrete and landscape contractor twice. And it was holding up a fourth account's monthly deck [source: M360/2026-09-04-ai-division-plan/PLAN.md, "Match-back: the differentiator, and the defect underneath it"; VAULT/12_Brain/03_Concepts/2026-09-07 - Conversion match-back is the differentiator.md, "The promise, and how often it has been made"]. **Thirteen** promises across four accounts.

Every one of those promises was made in good faith. Every one of them slipped. And the slippage was filed the way you'd file any late report: as a capacity problem. Too much to do, not enough hours, we'll get to it. It went in the queue as a reporting backlog, and we scheduled more of the work [source: same concept note, "The lesson"].

What was actually wrong

On September 7, 2026, somebody finally asked a different question. Not "why is the report late" but "what does the lead notification actually contain?"

The answer: a link. When a lead came in on those three accounts, the automation - a Zapier zap - sent an email to Gmail. The email said, in effect, "open this Zap run in Zapier." No name. No phone. No source. Nothing you could put next to a platform conversion and say "that's her"

[source: PLAN.md, same section; concept note, "Why it cannot be produced"].

You can't reconcile a link. No amount of reporting effort downstream produces a match when the payload never arrived. The report wasn't late. It was impossible, and had been for as long as the zap had been sending links.

The one account where it worked

A Pittsburgh residential and commercial painting company. Same tool, same kind of automation, one difference: its zap parses the lead fields into the email body. Name, phone, message, page, source. So on that one account the loop closes: you can take the platform export and the inbox and put a person against each event [source: PLAN.md, same section; concept note,

"Why it cannot be produced"].

One account of four. One configuration difference.

The access twist

There was a second, independent reason the Colorado Springs account couldn't have worked even with a better zap, and I covered it in chapter 4: we held Standard access on the Google Ads account and the client's own email address was the Admin, so the lead export through Zapier and Sheets couldn't be authorized [source: VAULT/01_Clients/Omega Landscaping/Agent Memory.md, "Direct lead capture and access audit - 2026-07-30"]. Two plumbing problems on the same pipe. Nine promises made on top of them.

The lesson, in one line

From our own internal note: "A repeated broken promise is usually one defect wearing thirteen costumes" [source: VAULT/12_Brain/03_Concepts/2026-09-07 - Conversion match-back is the differentiator.md, "The lesson"]. When the same thing slips on several accounts at once, it's not several problems. Look for the shared pipe before you schedule more of the work.

What we changed

Three things.

First, the fix is a configuration change to the zap on each account, not a reporting project. It's a change to a client's account, which means it needs that client's approval before we touch it, which means it lands account by account, not all at once [source: concept note, "The constraint that must hold"].

Second, a rule: **we don't put named-lead match-back on a proposal, a deck, or a report for an account until it has produced one true month on that account.** Not "it's coming." Not "we do this." Verified, on that account, with the names in the file. The rule holds before the fix and after it, because the fix is per account and so is the verification [source: PLAN.md, "It must not be sold before it is fixed"; concept note, "The constraint that must hold"].

Third, the question goes in the intake checklist. Before we promise a client anything about naming their leads, we open one notification email and read it. If the lead isn't in the body, the promise isn't made.

What this means for you

If your agency has promised you the list more than twice, stop asking for the list. Ask them this instead: "Forward me the last lead notification email your system sent you for my account." Then read it. If it has a name and a phone number in it, they can do the match-back and they're just not doing it. If it has a link, they can't, and no amount of pressure will make them able to. Either answer is useful. Only one of them is a capacity problem.

And if you're the agency reading this: I know. Go check the email.

07

How do I do a match-back with a spreadsheet?

Short answer. Export the platform's conversions with timestamps. Export your leads with names, timestamps, and source fields. Put them side by side. Match each conversion to one person by time, source, and click ID. Mark the leftovers "unmatched" and don't guess. Then walk each matched person forward: contacted, quoted, booked, paid. It's a spreadsheet, not a software project.

Once the plumbing from chapter 4 is in, the match-back is clerical. Here's the worksheet. Two tabs and a rule.

Tab 1: Platform

One row per conversion event the platform reported for the month.

COLUMN	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Date and time	The platform's conversion report, set to your timezone
Campaign and ad group	Same
Conversion action	Which counter fired: form, call, click-to-call
Click ID	gc1id or fbclid, if the platform exposes it; often it won't
Platform value	Whatever the platform assigned; ignore it for now
Match	Filled in by you: a lead ID from Tab 2, or "unmatched"

Google Ads gives you conversions by day and by action; getting them by timestamp may take a lead-form export or a Tag Manager event log. Meta's Leads Center exports native lead IDs. When we reconciled the bridal boutique's September 1-3 window, the native export gave us 2

distinct lead IDs, one from Facebook and one from Instagram, with zero duplicates [source: clients/kimberly-james-bridal/deliverables/2026-09-04-daily-lead-intake-audit/native-september-verified.md; verified outcome, lead identity only]. Two rows. Two IDs. That's what a clean Tab 1 looks like on a small account.

Tab 2: Leads

One row per human who contacted you, from any source.

COLUMN	WHERE IT COMES FROM
Lead ID	Your own running number
Date and time	The email timestamp or the call log
Name, phone, email	The email body (chapter 4, fix 2) or the call log
Channel	Form, call, chat, walk-in
Tracking number or form name	Which number rang; which form submitted
Page	From the notification
Click ID and UTMs	From the notification
Source (your call)	The dropdown from chapter 4, fix 3
Status	Received, deduplicated, contacted, qualified, booked, won
Revenue	If won, the invoice amount
Excluded?	Test, spam, solicitation, duplicate, with a reason

The rule: match in this order, and stop when you can't

1. **Click ID.** If the platform row and the lead row share a click ID, that's a match. Done.
2. **Tracking number plus time.** A "call" conversion at 2:14 pm and a call to the ads tracking number at 2:14 pm: match.

3. **Form name plus time.** A form conversion at 10:03 am and a notification from that form at 10:03 am: match.

4. **Nothing.** Write "unmatched." Do not assign it to the nearest lead because it feels right.

Then exclude before you count. Tests, solicitations, duplicates. On the bridal boutique's dashboard for July 1-15, 2026, 28 verified form and Meta contacts sat next to 5 test-and-routing rows we removed, and the calls and appointments columns said "pending, not zero" [source: M360/2026-07-19-all-client-paid-media-report.md, "Latest Momentum dashboard state"; verified outcome for contacts, appointments unverified]. On the painting account, 22 automation runs became 4 people after 18 solicitations, tests and duplicate replies were classified out [source: Fagan attribution audit, "Production repair completed July 13, 2026"]. Exclusion is where most of the platform total goes. Say how many you excluded and why.

What you end up with

Three piles.

- **Matched.** A platform event with a person on it. Walk them forward: contacted? quoted? booked? paid? That's the ladder from chapter 2, filled in with names.
- **Unmatched platform events.** The counter fired and nobody arrived. Spam, a double count, a tap that didn't connect, a tag on the wrong thing. This pile is the size of the leak in chapter 3. Big pile, bad plumbing.
- **Unmatched leads.** A person arrived and no counter fired. Organic, referral, repeat, or an ad lead your tracking missed. This pile tells you whether the platform is under-reporting, which happens too.

Report the piles as counts of people, with the exclusions and the unmatched stated. "Google reported 13 conversions. We matched 5 to named people. 2 were duplicates. 6 are unmatched. Of the 5, 3 were quoted and 1 booked." Those are made-up numbers to show the shape of the sentence, not a result from any account. But it's a sentence a client can check against their own phone. It's the sentence we couldn't write on three of four accounts, and it's the sentence this book is about.

One thing I'm not going to show you

A finished month from one of our own accounts. The one account where the loop closes is one account. When the match-back is producing true months on every account we run it for, it'll be in those clients' reports, with their permission or not at all. It won't be a screenshot in an ebook.

If that seems like a strange thing to withhold in a book about match-back, chapter 6 is why.

What should I demand from any agency, including Momentum?

Short answer. Names. A monthly report that lists real people by first name or initials and source, with the platform total in a separate column, and the word "unverified" wherever the two don't meet. Admin access held by you. One primary conversion action per real outcome. A written definition of "lead." And the honesty to write "pending validation" instead of a number that flatters everyone.

How to read the report you already get

Our reporting contract says every client-facing ad report has to state the exact period, the comparison period, the timezone, the attribution setting, how fresh the source data is, the tracking limitations, the business outcomes separately from platform events, and the next actions with owners [source: M360/2026-07-26-paid-media-reporting-contract.md, "Outcome" and the required-deliverables table]. It also says, in one line I'd put on a wall: "A platform screenshot alone is not an ad report" [source: same file].

Hold your current report against that. Is there a period? An attribution window? A sentence about what the tracking can't see? Is there a column of people, or only a column of events? If the "leads" number has no names behind it and no note saying why, you're looking at a platform total dressed as a result.

The confession in our own reports

Every active paid-media report we sent for July and August 2026 carries "pending validation" for qualified leads, booked jobs and revenue [source: research/evidence-bank.md §E, item 1; M360/2026-08-31-august-2026-paid-media-monthly-reports/reports-data.mjs line 3]. The only dollar outcome anywhere in our client files is a \$9,600 job the painting company's owner told us about on August 20, 2026,

which we record as client-reported, not invoice-verified, and not attributed to any channel

[source: clients/fagan-painting/organic-search/2026-08-27-aeo-baseline.md, "Lead path (context, not AEO success)"; client-reported].

I'm putting that in print on purpose. "Pending validation" is not a feature. It's a confession that the plumbing isn't done, written in the report instead of hidden under a trend line. I'd rather send that sentence than a number I can't defend. If your agency has never sent you that sentence, either their plumbing is perfect or they've never checked. One of those is more common.

The list

Ask for these. Any agency that flinches at one of them is telling you something.

1. **Admin access, held by you**, on every ad account, the tag manager, the analytics property, and the form tool. The agency is a guest.
2. **One primary conversion action per real outcome**, written down. What counts as a form lead. What counts as a call. Call counting set to One.
3. **A written definition of "lead"** that excludes tests, spam, solicitations and duplicates, and says who classifies them.
4. **A lead notification with the lead in it**. Forward me the last one. If it's a link, we're not there yet.
5. **A tracking number on the ads**, with your real number kept primary on your listing.
6. **A source field on every CRM record**, and the rule that no record is created without it.
7. **A monthly list of people, not events**. First names or initials, source, status on the ladder. The platform total in a separate column.
8. **The word "unmatched"** where a conversion has no person, and a count of how many.
9. **Every report dated**, with an attribution window and a "what this can't see" section.
0. **No number without a source**. If they can't tell you which export a figure came from, it's not a figure.

Hold us to the same list. The next section is the only place in this book I'll ask you for anything.

The one ask

If you want a second pair of eyes on your own plumbing, we do a free 15-minute snapshot: three observations from your actual accounts, each one with evidence, and one suggested next step [source: M360/2026-09-04-ai-division-plan/PLAN.md, "Three offers with finite delivery contracts"]. It's not an audit and it's not a pitch. It's the first three things we'd check, checked. If one of them is "your lead notification is a link," you'll know in fifteen minutes what took us thirteen promises to find out.

FAQ

What's the difference between a conversion and a lead? A conversion is an event: a tag fired because something happened on a page or a phone number was tapped. A lead is a person who contacted you and might buy. Conversions can include tests, spam, duplicates and taps that never connected. A lead has a name. The platform reports the first. Only you can confirm the second.

Is a tap on a phone number a call? No. It's an intent to call. Google counts it as a "call from ads" conversion by default. Whether the call connected, how long it lasted, and whether it was a customer or a vendor are things only a call log or call tracking can tell you. Our own file for a client's phone-link fix says it "does not prove a connected call" [source: clients/omega-landscaping/paid-media/reviews/2026-09-04-phone-link-published.md]. Treat taps as taps.

What is a click ID and why do I care? A click ID (gclid from Google, fbclid from Meta) is a code the platform appends to the link when someone clicks your ad. If your form captures it and your notification email carries it, you can match that person to that click with certainty. It's the closest thing to a fingerprint in this whole process. If your forms don't capture it, that's the first thing to fix.

Can I do this without a CRM? Yes. A spreadsheet with a row per lead and a Source column is a CRM for attribution purposes. What you can't do without is the rule that every lead gets a row and every row gets a source. Buy software when the spreadsheet gets annoying, not before.

Will a tracking number hurt my local search ranking? It can, if you put it where your real number should be. Keep your real number as the primary on Google Business Profile and in every directory. Use the tracking number only on ads and their landing pages, or swap it in by session so organic visitors and Google see the real one. I don't have a measurement of the effect either way from our own accounts; this is practice, not a study.

Are Meta lead-form leads real people? Sometimes. Meta's instant forms can pre-fill from the profile, so people submit without meaning to. Qualification questions help; the bridal boutique's campaign requires four of them plus phone verification by text [source: clients/kimberly-james-bridal/paid-media/meta-qualified-lead-campaign-2026-07-27.md]. Of four lead records pulled from that account's inbox

in late August, two answered yes to all four questions [source: clients/kimberly-james-bridal/deliverables/2026-09-04-daily-lead-intake-audit/README.md, "Verified result"; self-reported answers]. Real people, half of them qualified. Match them like everything else.

My agency says attribution is "modeled." Is that fine? For a business with two channels and a phone, no. Modeled attribution splits credit across touches using the platform's own math. It's fine for a national retailer. For you it turns a question with a checkable answer - "who was this person?" - into a percentage nobody can check. Ask for the names first. Model later, if ever.

How many of my conversions should be matchable? I don't have a benchmark and I'm not going to invent one. What I can tell you is the goal isn't 100% matched, it's 100% labeled: every platform event is either a named person, an exclusion with a reason, or "unmatched." A big unmatched pile is not a failure of the worksheet. It's the size of your leak, measured.

What do I do with the unmatched pile? Look at it once a month for patterns. Unmatched events clustered at the same minute are a double count. Unmatched events with gibberish are spam. Unmatched leads with no click ID from a source you advertise on mean the form isn't capturing it. Fix the pattern, not the row.

Does AI fix any of this? It fixes the boring middle. Reading 22 notification emails and sorting them into 4 people and 18 solicitations is exactly the kind of work a model does well [source: Fagan attribution audit; the classification was done from raw notification bodies]. What it can't do is invent a name that was never in the email. If the payload didn't arrive, there's nothing to parse. Fix the pipe first; then let the machine read what comes through it.

What to do Monday

An owner's own audit. One sitting. The question is: which of my conversions can I name?

- ☐ Log in to your own Google Ads account. If you can't, or you're not the admin, that's item one and it comes before everything else.
- ☐ Open Conversions. Count the enabled actions. Write the number down. If it's more than one per real outcome (form, call), note which are duplicates.
- ☐ Check the call action. Is it counting Every or One?
- ☐ Find your last ten conversions by date. Put them in a list.
- ☐ Open your inbox and find the last ten lead notification emails. Do they have a name and a phone number in the body, or a link?
- ☐ Try to put each of the ten conversions next to one of the ten emails or calls. Count the matches. Count the ones you can't.
- ☐ Check your phone log for the same days. How many calls came in? How many were answered?
- ☐ Look at your website's thank-you page. Is it blocked from search?
- ☐ Look at your forms. Do they capture the page URL, the UTMs, and the click ID? Submit a test with ?gc1id=TEST123 on the URL and see whether it shows up in the notification. Then delete the test.
- ☐ Look at your CRM or lead sheet. Is there a Source column? Is it filled in?
- ☐ Check your Google Business Profile. Is the primary number your real number?
- ☐ Ask your agency for the last lead notification their system received for your account. Read it.
- ☐ Ask your agency for the written definition of "lead" they report against. If there isn't one, write one together this week.
- ☐ Write down how many of the ten conversions you could name. That number, not the platform total, is your attribution today.

If you could name all ten, you're ahead of most agencies, including where we were in September 2026. If you couldn't name any, you've found the pipe. Either way you know more than you did before you sat down.

About Momentum AI

Momentum AI is the AI division of Momentum Digital, a marketing agency founded in Philadelphia in 2015 [source: M360/2026-09-04-momentum-digital-sales-deck/SOURCES.md, "/about-us/" capture]. Momentum Digital is a Google Partner and a Meta Business Partner [source: same file]. Its site is needmomentum.com.

The division builds three things for local service businesses: a lead-operations workflow that takes one intake source to one destination with routing, duplicate protection and an exception queue; an AI visibility program that measures whether a business is cited when buyers ask AI engines, with engine, prompt, date and source on every observation; and a campaign production system that produces copy and design against a written brand file [source: M360/2026-09-04-ai-division-plan/PLAN.md, "Three offers with finite delivery contracts"]. Each has a written acceptance test. None guarantees rankings, citations, leads or revenue [source: same file].

Named-lead match-back is offered only on an account where the lead payload has been verified end to end and has produced a true month. Where it hasn't, the report says "pending validation."

Built, not prompted.

To ask for the free 15-minute snapshot, contact Momentum through needmomentum.com.



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